

« I completely understand Igor Stimac. If I am the national team coach, I would like more time »

MANOLO MARQUEZ

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Four years ago, Hyderabad FC had set its course with Albert Roca as its head coach before the Spaniard got a call from FC Barcelona. The club then turned to another Spanish native, Manolo Marquez, who came in and changed the club's fortunes. In just his second season, he led the *Nizams* to the Indian Super League (ISL) title and into another playoff the following year, amid turmoil at the club.

The Catalan has since taken over the reins at FC Goa and is leading the charge for the club's return to the top of Indian football once again. *Sportstar* caught up with Marquez on the sidelines of the *Sportstar Goa Conclave* to talk about his time in Hyderabad, the future of Indian football, and more.

What do you make of the current situation at Hyderabad FC with the players and coaching staff leaving the club over lack of payments?

I am very sad about this situation. I had a very good relationship with the owner. We spoke a lot because of the bubble during the COVID-19 pandemic. My feeling is that they didn't value what went behind all the wins, so how will they know what they are losing?

The problem is that they don't have the correct people managing the club. We had the most incredible

group of players with an incredible atmosphere, which was the key to success. But the kind of problems they have now were there last season as well. We played all of last season without salaries. But that group was committed, and the guys were good; they played well, and we had a very nice season.

I always say that finishing second in the regular season and losing the semifinals of the playoffs on penalties [in 2022-23] was better and more difficult than when we were champions the previous season [2021-22]. I am very sad for the players and the staff because they went more than six months without salaries; I hope they can solve this situation as soon as possible. Because these people and the people of Hyderabad deserve a team in the ISL.

At the end of the third season at Hyderabad FC, you faced difficult circumstances and things ended on a sour note. After that, what prompted you to take up the job at FC Goa?

Out of the three seasons, I don't want to remember just the last months in Hyderabad and what happened in Kerala in the Super Cup. It was a complete disaster. They didn't pay the players and the staff, and we had to stay in two different hotels. It was a very bad way to finish three

wonderful seasons there.

But if you receive a call from FC Goa and you see the structure of the club, you know it's a real club. It has a developmental team, a youth team, an Under-15 team, and even one with the kids. I am very comfortable at this kind of club, where the facilities are very good. I would indeed like to have more Goan players on the main team. Let's see if we can do it in the future.

In the cricket panel, there was talk about how Goans like being laid back and enjoying their simple way of life. Is that culture prevalent among the talent in football?

I think every country is the same. Even in Spain, especially because of the weather, the people in the north are completely different from the people in the south. I worked in the Canary Islands, and it's sunny all year, similar to Goa. At Las Palmas, the players are very, very good with the ball, but when it comes to practical stuff, they go, 'Why do we have to do these exercises?'

Here, it's a little similar. The players are not used to or don't like working without the ball. Unfortunately, in football, you need to work on both aspects — with and without the ball. In places where the weather is very good, it's more difficult to work on these aspects. I